HOW TO TALK ABOUT

POWER BUILDING



A department-by-department training guide

JUSTICE OUTSIDE · STAFF REFERENCE · 2026

Why this guide exists

Power-building looks different from where each of us sits. Grantmaking experiences it through grantee relationships. Movement Building experiences it through coalitions. Programs experiences it through fellows. Operations experiences it through the systems that move money on time.

Every department is part of the same cycle. But each of us needs language that fits where we are in the work. This guide is built that way.

How to use this guide

Find your department. You will find:

- *Your Role in Power-Building (the short version)*
- *Your 30-Second Pitch (anywhere, anytime)*
- *Your 2-Minute Version (funders, peers, board members)*
- *Questions You Might Get Asked (and how to answer them)*
- *Phrases That Work*

Use what serves you. Adapt what does not. The point is not to memorize scripts. The point is to walk into any conversation with the language you need to represent this work and the people behind it.

MOVEMENT BUILDING & ADVOCACY

Lead on Advocate

Your Role in Power-Building

You lead movement building, coalition coordination, the advocacy hubs in California, Washington, and Pennsylvania. And the National Advocacy Hub known as Root Hub. You recruit and train grantees and program alumnx as grassroots advocates. You lead our biennial conference. You connect community priorities to legislative action at local, state, and federal levels.

Your work is the visible edge of power-building. When community voice shows up in policy rooms, that is your output.

Your 30-Second Pitch

I lead movement building and advocacy at Justice Outside. We don't advocate for communities. We advocate with them. Our grantees and program alumnx become the advocates shaping policy on the issues that affect their land, water, and outdoor spaces. My job is to coordinate the coalitions, train the grassroots leaders, and create the pathways that move community priorities into legislation.

Your 2-Minute Version

Justice Outside advances environmental justice through three connected pillars: Advocate, Fund, and Build. I lead the Advocate pillar.

Our advocacy agenda centers four areas where community voice is most urgently needed:

- Indigenous Sovereignty and Land Rematriation
- Green Jobs and Blue Economies
- Healing and Wellness
- Environmental Education

We run advocacy hubs in California, Washington, and Pennsylvania that connect grassroots groups to coordinated policy strategy. We organized our biennial conference, which brought 200+ changemakers to Philadelphia in 2025. What makes our advocacy different is who carries it. We invest in grantees and program alumnx so they have the skills, networks, and platforms to speak for themselves in legislative rooms. We are the infrastructure. They are the voice.

Questions You Might Get Asked

Q: *Aren't you doing what other environmental advocacy orgs do?*
A: We are an intermediary, not a substitute. Most national advocacy orgs lead with their own staff voice. We lead with grassroots voice. We resource and coordinate so community leaders can speak directly to power. That is a different model and it produces different outcomes.

Q: *How is this different from organizing?*
A: Local groups do the deep neighborhood organizing. We coordinate at the regional and national level and connect organizers across geographies so their work compounds. Both are necessary. Neither is the other.

Q: *What's Justice Outside's position on [specific policy]?*
A: Our position follows community lead. Here is what our grantees and coalition partners are saying on this issue. I can connect you with leaders working on it directly.

Q: *How do you decide which campaigns to run?*
A: Community priorities surface through our grantee relationships, advocacy hubs, and program alumnx. Those priorities shape our campaign agenda. We do not pick issues from a national strategy desk. We pick up what community is already carrying.

Phrases That Work

- We advocate with communities, not for them
- Coalition coordination
- Grassroots advocates
- Movement infrastructure
- Community-led campaigns
- Advocacy hubs

GRANTMAKING

Lead on Fund

Your Role in Power-Building
You lead trust-based funding design, grantee relationships, and cohort learning. You move flexible, renewable grants ranging from $10,000 to $40,000 of annual support to organizations led by Black, Indigenous, and People of Color. You are often the first national funder a grantee partner has ever had. Your work is where the trust gets built. Every relationship you carry is part of the proof that this model works.

Your 30-Second Pitch
I work in grantmaking at Justice Outside. We move flexible, trust-based funding directly to organizations led by Black, Indigenous, and People of Color. In 2025, we moved $4 million to 180+ community-led organizations across 10 regions. Most of our partners had never been funded by a national intermediary before they came to us. Independent evaluation found that 96 percent of them report improved financial stability after partnering with us.

Your 2-Minute Version
Our grantmaking has moved more than $4 million to 180+ community-led organizations in 2025 alone, our most expansive year yet. We work across ten regions of the country and prioritize organizations led by Black, Indigenous, and People of Color.

We focus on five funding priorities: Health and Wellness; Land and Water Access; Grassroots Organizing and Mobilization; Youth Education Fund (our largest priority); and Economic Opportunity. Our standard grants are flexible, renewable grants ranging from $10,000 to $40,000. We do not require 501(c)(3) status or any size threshold to apply.

We honor and respect grantee capacity. We use video and phone applications, simplified reporting, and one-on-one support so even the smallest organizations can participate. The Bowman evaluation, an independent year-long study released in 2025, found 95 percent of grantee partners say our process feels co-designed and supportive. The other half of our work is connecting grantees to each other, to additional funders, and to the leadership development programs that strengthen their long-term capacity.

Questions You Might Get Asked

Q: *What's trust-based grantmaking?*
A: Long-term, flexible, low-bureaucracy funding designed to respect grantee time and capacity. We start with the belief that grassroots groups already have the answers to the challenges they face. We fund flexibly, and keep reporting minimal.

Q: *How do you choose grantees?*
A: Community-led selection. We follow grantee networks and trusted referrals. We prioritize organizations philanthropy has historically overlooked, including those without 501(c)(3) status and leaders who do not yet have national funder relationships.

Q: *What about due diligence?*
A: Trust-based does not mean no rigor. It means rigor that fits grantee capacity. We meet legal and funder compliance standards while keeping grantee paperwork minimal. The complexity sits with us, not with them.

Q: *What kind of impact do grantees actually have?*
A: Grantees lead community advocacy, restore land, organize youth, fight permits, and build coalitions in their own neighborhoods. Bowman found that 96 percent of our grantee partners report improved financial stability through our partnership, and for many that meant the difference between survival and closing their doors.

Phrases That Work

- Trust-based
- Grants are flexible & renewable
- Community-led priorities
- Co-designed relationship
- First funder in
- Grantee partners

PROGRAMS

Lead on Build, Co-lead on Advocate

Your Role in Power-Building

You design and deliver the Rising Leaders Fellowship, the Network for Network Leaders, and Pathfinders. You coordinate advocacy hub partnerships and connect program alumnx to advocacy channels. You provide capacity-building support that turns grants into long-term leadership.

Your work develops the leaders who will transform this movement. The people you support today will lead the field tomorrow.

Your 30-Second Pitch

I work in programs at Justice Outside. We develop the leaders who will transform the environmental movement. In 2025 we onboarded 58 fellows from 52 organizations across 15 states. We are not training people to participate in the movement as it is. We are developing the people who will transform it.

Your 2-Minute Version

Programs at Justice Outside is where leadership development meets movement building. We run three signature initiatives.

The Rising Leaders Fellowship onboarded 58 fellows in 2025, from 52 organizations in 15 states. The cohort graduated during one of the most difficult years in recent memory. Fellows redesigned their impact projects in real time to respond to immigration raids, climate disasters, and economic hardship in their communities. Network for Network Leaders convened 25 leaders across 2 cohorts in 7 states, in partnership with Lawrence Hall of Science. Pathfinders is our 5-month professional development program for Justice Outside alumnx.

What makes our programs different is what happens after. We don't just train leaders and let them go. We connect alumnx into advocacy hubs, into coalition campaigns, into ongoing learning communities. Many become grantees. Many move into the boards and senior roles that govern this field. The fellowship is not a credential. It is an entry point into a power-building ecosystem.

Questions You Might Get Asked

Q: *What makes your fellowship different from other leadership programs?*
A: Most leadership programs end at graduation. Ours is an entry point. Fellows leave with networks, advocacy training, and connection to a power-building ecosystem that includes grantmaking, coalition work, and ongoing learning. The relationship continues for years.

Q: *What happens to alumnx?*
A: They become advocates, organizers, board members, and conference presenters. Some become grantees. Some join our advocacy hubs. The cycle compounds. Each cohort strengthens the network the next cohort joins.

Q: *Who is the fellowship for?*
A: Grassroots leaders working at the intersection of environmental justice, racial justice, and community wellbeing, especially those whose leadership has been overlooked by traditional philanthropy and traditional leadership pipelines.

Phrases That Work

- Leadership development as movement infrastructure
- Cohort
- Alumnx
- Rising Leaders Fellowship
- Network for Network Leaders
- Pathfinders
- Power-building ecosystem

LEARNING & IMPACT

Co-lead on Build

Your Role in Power-Building
You build the capacity that makes power-building real across the field. Through training, consulting, and peer cohorts, you help organizations shift internal policies, practices, and beliefs so they can build power with the communities they serve. You also lead our research and evaluation work, providing the evidence base that fuels advocacy and funder confidence.Your work goes beyond raising awareness. You help organizations create lasting, systemic change. Without that, the trust-based model is a story. With it, the model becomes a documented practice that other intermediaries can follow.

Your 30-Second Pitch
I work in Learning and Impact at Justice Outside. We help organizations across the environmental movement shift power, redesign their work, and build authentic relationships with the communities they serve. We do this through training workshops, peer cohorts, community workshops, and organizational consulting, all grounded in a trauma-informed, equity-centered approach. We've worked with 25+ organizations including Whole Kids Foundation, California Coastal Commission, Parks California, East Bay Regional Parks, Outward Bound, and the U.S. Fish & Wildlife Service.

Your 2-Minute Version

Learning & Impact at Justice Outside has four service lines, each designed to meet organizations where they are.

Training Workshops are interactive sessions on power dynamics, trauma-informed care, boundaries and accountability, and how to build more equitable practices in environmental work. Topics range from foundational conversations on the 4 I's of Oppression to deeper work on apologies, accountability, and intersectional care. Pricing and a full topic list are available in our Service Guide.

Learning Lab Peer Cohorts bring leaders from different organizations together for collaborative problem-solving. Participants share strategies, develop coordinated approaches to environmental justice challenges, and learn from grassroots, community-led initiatives. The peer model is what makes the work compound across the field.

Community Workshops offer supportive learning environments to explore ideas like curriculum redesign using the 7 Equity Principles, asset-based language and storytelling, equitable recruiting and hiring, and environmental trauma-informed care. They're designed for organizations refreshing foundational knowledge or applying new skills directly to their work.

Organizational Consulting is for organizations ready to do deeper structural work. We partner on power analysis, transformation strategy, capacity building for power shifting, implementation coaching, and cohort-based learning. This is long-term, customized partnership.

Questions You Might Get Asked

Q: What makes your training different from other DEI work?
A: We use a trauma-informed lens that acknowledges the historical harm tied to the environmental movement and outdoor experiences for Black, Indigenous, and People of Color. We don't just raise awareness. We help organizations rebuild their internal policies, practices, and decision-making so power actually shifts.

Q: Who do you work with?
A: 25+ organizations and institutions across the field, from foundations and federal agencies to state parks departments and outdoor education nonprofits. Past clients include Whole Kids Foundation, California Coastal Commission, Parks California, East Bay Regional Parks, Outward Bound, and the U.S. Fish & Wildlife Service.

Q: How do organizations get started?
A: They fill out our Training & Consulting Inquiry Form, then our team sets up a complimentary call to talk through fit. From there, we customize what makes sense for them, whether that's a one-time workshop, a peer cohort, or longer-term organizational consulting.

Q: Where can I learn more?
A: justiceoutside.org/learning has the full service menu, pathways guide, and pricing.

Phrases That Work

- Trauma-informed, equity-centered approach
- Power-shifting practice
- Learning alongside
- Brave learning spaces
- Customized partnership
- Evidence base for the model

DEVELOPMENT

Co-lead on Fund

Your Role in Power-Building

You raise revenue, cultivate major funders, and align funder relationships with community priorities. You are the bridge between philanthropy and grassroots movements. Every dollar you raise flows into the trust-based ecosystem the rest of the team operates.

Your role is also to translate. Funders want impact. Communities want trust. Your job is to hold both at once.

Your 30-Second Pitch

I work in development at Justice Outside. My job is to raise the funding that flows directly to grassroots organizations on the front lines of environmental justice. We are a national intermediary led by Black, Indigenous, and People of Color, and we have built deep relationships with 180+ community-led organizations. A partnership with Justice Outside is a partnership with every organization in our network.

Your 2-Minute Version

Justice Outside is a national environmental justice intermediary. We have moved millions in flexible, trust-based funding to community-led organizations since 2010, including more than $4 million to 180+ organizations in 2025 alone.

Our funder partners choose us for three reasons. Reach: we have spent 15 years building relationships in communities most foundations cannot access directly. Trust: independent evaluation by Bowman Performance Consulting found 96 percent of our grantee partners report improved financial stability through our trust-based approach. Infrastructure: we hold the operational, compliance, and reporting load so grantees can focus on the work.

What sets us apart is the integrated power-building model. We do not just regrant. We pair every dollar with advocacy training and leadership development. That is why we won the ABFE 2026 Institutional Award for Philanthropic Leadership and why the USDA Forest Service trusted us to lead Rooting Justice in 2025. The model produces outcomes traditional grantmaking does not.

Questions You Might Get Asked

Q: *Why fund through an intermediary instead of going direct?*
A: Reach, trust, and infrastructure. Our grantee partners are often outside traditional philanthropic networks. We have spent 15 years building those relationships. We absorb the compliance and reporting load that would otherwise sit with grantees. And we pair every grant with leadership development and advocacy training that direct grantmaking cannot easily provide.

Q: *What's your administrative rate?*
A: [Have your current number ready.] What I will say is that our administrative costs are what make the trust-based model possible. We absorb compliance, reporting, and capacity support so grantees do not have to. That is part of what funders are paying for when they fund through us.

Q: *How do you prevent grantmaking bias?*
A: Community-led priority setting. Grantee feedback loops. Transparent criteria. Our annual independent evaluation surfaces where our process is working and where it is not. We adjust based on what grantees tell us.

Q: *Can we restrict our gift to a specific region or program?*
A: We can talk through what aligns. Our preference is unrestricted or program-restricted funding rather than project-restricted, because that flexibility is what makes our trust-based approach possible. I would love to set up a conversation about how your priorities map to ours.

Phrases That Work

- National environmental justice intermediary
- Power-building
- Trust-based grantmaking
- Flexible capital
- Community-led priorities
- 180+ community-led organizations

COMMS & ADVOCACY

Co-leads all three pillars

Your Role in Power-Building

You lead public narrative, media strategy, campaign messaging, and coalition communications. You amplify grantee partner stories and shape how the environmental justice movement is seen and heard. You also build the funder communications that strengthen Development's relationships.Your role sits at the intersection of every pillar. Comms is where power-building becomes visible to people who have never heard the term.

Your 30-Second Pitch

I lead communications and advocacy at Justice Outside. My team shapes how the environmental justice movement gets seen and heard, through media, campaigns, and the stories of grantee partners doing the work. We center community voice in everything we publish. When we lead a campaign, the community priorities are the campaign. We don't put our voice over theirs.

Your 2-Minute Version

Comms at Justice Outside is built to do three things at once: shift narrative, support advocacy, and amplify grantee partners.

On narrative, we co-authored the Nature Gap report with the Center for American Progress and Conservation Science Partners in February 2026. The findings, that communities of color are 3 times more likely to live in nature-deprived areas and 74 percent of people in those areas are communities of color, gave the field a shared evidence base for what frontline communities have always known.

On campaigns, we ran our 2026 Earth Month campaign "For the Land and Its People," which centered the intersection of environmental and immigration justice and reached over 12,000 funders, partners, and community members across five tiers of outreach.

On grantee stories, we run an ongoing community storytelling project called "Power in Practice," with bilingual media releases and on-camera support so grantee partners tell their stories on their own terms. The through line is consent, voice, and centering the people closest to the work.

Questions You Might Get Asked

Q: *How do you balance Justice Outside's voice with grantee voice?*
A: Grantee voice comes first. We provide the platform; we do not substitute our voice for theirs. When we issue a statement under JO's name, we do it because community partners have asked us to or because it strengthens what they are already saying.

Q: *What's your media strategy?*
A: Earned media tied to community priorities. We pitch what grantees are leading, not what we want to say. Our Nature Gap report rollout used coordinated outreach across seven grantee community geographies so local stories drove local coverage.

Q: *How do you handle sensitive narratives, especially around immigration or political issues?*
A: With consent, with care, and in coordination with the leaders most affected. The default is: amplify, do not appropriate.

Phrases That Work

- Community voice
- Narrative shift
- Grantee partner stories
- Earned media
- Bilingual communications
- Power in Practice

PEOPLE OPS

Supports all three pillars

Your Role in Power-Building
You lead hiring and retention of mission-aligned staff, internal organizational culture, staff development, and wellness. The way Justice Outside operates internally has to match the values it carries externally. If staff do not experience trust here, the trust-based model is a slogan. Your work is what makes it real on the inside.

Your 30-Second Pitch
I work in people operations at Justice Outside. My role is to make sure how we work internally reflects the values we hold externally. We can't ask grantees to lead through trust if our staff doesn't experience trust here. Hiring, onboarding, professional development, wellness, all of it is part of power-building because the staff is what holds the work together.

Your 2-Minute Version
Justice Outside operates through a power-building framework. That framework starts with how we treat each other.

On hiring, we recruit for mission alignment, lived experience, and the skills our movement needs. On onboarding, every new staff member learns the trust-based values that shape our external work because they are the same values that shape our internal culture. On development, we invest in staff growth the way we ask funders to invest in grantees: flexibly, with trust, and over the long term.

On wellness, we treat staff capacity as movement infrastructure. The work we do is heavy. Coalition coordination, advocacy, sustained relationships with frontline communities. People burn out when organizations do not invest in their wellbeing. We invest because the movement needs us all to be here next year.

Questions You Might Get Asked

Q: ***How is HR part of power-building?***
A: Because how we treat staff is how we treat partners. Trust starts internally. If we ask grantees to lead through trust-based relationships and our own staff experiences something different, the model is hollow. People Ops is what keeps the model honest.

Q: *What's distinctive about Justice Outside's people practices?*
A: We invest in staff growth flexibly, with trust, and over the long term. We treat wellness as essential, not optional (after 5 years, JO staff can take a 3-month paid sabbatical). We hire for mission alignment and lived experience, not just credentials. And we model the kind of leadership development we offer externally.

Phrases That Work

- Internal culture mirrors external values
- Staff wellness as movement infrastructure
- Mission-aligned hiring
- Trust-based culture
- People Ops

FINANCE OPS

Supports all three pillars

Your Role in Power-Building

You manage grant administration, compliance, financial reporting, and the payment infrastructure that moves money to grantee partners. You absorb operational complexity so grantees do not have to.

When a grantee receives funding on time without unnecessary bureaucracy, that is your work making trust-based principles real.

Your 30-Second Pitch

I work in finance operations at Justice Outside. My job is to make sure trust-based funding actually reaches grantee partners on time and without unnecessary bureaucracy. When a grantee receives funding without onerous compliance demands, that's finance operations making power-building real. Compliance, infrastructure, reporting, all of it has to work in service of community, not against it.

Your 2-Minute Version

Finance Ops is the operational backbone of the trust-based model.

On grant administration, we move funds to grantee partners on schedule, with minimal documentation burden on their side. We absorb the compliance complexity so they can focus on the work in their communities.

On compliance, we meet the requirements of our funders, the IRS, and our regulatory environment without passing those burdens onto grantees. That is a deliberate operational choice. It costs us more on the back end. It saves grantee capacity, which is the entire point.

On reporting, we provide the financial transparency funders need to trust us with multi-million dollar grants, while keeping grantee reporting simple, narrative-led, and respectful of their time.

Questions You Might Get Asked

Q: How is finance ops part of power-building?
A: When we get the operations right, grantees do not waste time on bureaucracy. That time goes back into their work. Every hour we save on the operational side is an hour grantees spend on the community side. That is power-building, even though it does not look like it from the outside.

Q: What's different about your compliance approach?
A: We meet legal and funder requirements without imposing them on grantees. We absorb the complexity. Most intermediaries pass that complexity through. We do not.

Phrases That Work

- Operational infrastructure for the movement
- Trust-based principles made operational
- Absorbing complexity
- Compliance that respects grantee capacity

EXECUTIVE TEAM

Supports all three pillars

Your Role in Power-Building

You hold strategic oversight of the power-building framework. You cultivate major funder relationships, lead coalition partnerships at the executive level, and represent Justice Outside in the rooms where decisions about funding, policy, and the future of environmental justice get made.

Your role is to carry the vision externally while making sure the agenda is set by community

internally. Both at once. Always.

Your 30-Second Pitch

I'm part of the executive team at Justice Outside. Our role is to hold the strategy, cultivate the relationships, and represent the movement in the rooms where decisions get made about funding, policy, and the future of environmental justice. We carry the vision, but we don't set the agenda. The community does. Our job is to make sure power-building shapes every level of philanthropy and policy that touches our work.

Your 2-Minute Version

Justice Outside is a national environmental justice intermediary advancing equity in outdoor and environmental movements through trust-based grantmaking, advocacy, and network building. Our power-building framework, Advocate, Fund, and Build, has moved more than $4 million to 180+ community-led organizations in 2025 alone, our most expansive year yet.

Our model has produced measurable outcomes that traditional grantmaking does not. Independent evaluation by Bowman Performance Consulting found 96 percent of our grantee partners report improved financial stability through our trust-based approach. ABFE recognized that work with the 2026 Institutional Award for Philanthropic Leadership.

What makes us a model worth scaling is the integration. Most intermediaries do one of these things well. We do all three together. The integration is the point. By 2030, we see a national advocacy infrastructure built by and for the communities it serves and a grantmaking model that has become the standard for trust-based philanthropy.

Questions You Might Get Asked

Q: *What's Justice Outside's strategy?*
A: Power-building. Three pillars: Advocate, Fund, Build. Working as an integrated cycle, not separate programs. Community sets the agenda. We resource, coordinate, and represent.

Q: *What's your role versus the field?*
A: We are a national intermediary. We resource, coordinate, and represent. We do not substitute for community-level work. We exist to make community-led work possible at scale.

Q: *How do you measure success?*
A: Whether communities most affected by environmental injustice are moving into positions of real decision-making power. The Bowman evaluation captures the financial and organizational outcomes. Our advocacy wins capture the policy outcomes. Our leadership pipeline captures the field outcomes. Together they tell us whether the model is working.

Q: *What does Justice Outside need most right now?*
A: Sustained, multi-year unrestricted funding. Funders willing to follow our trust-based approach. Coalition partners willing to share platforms and credit. And other intermediaries willing to learn from and adopt this model so the field can scale what works.

Phrases That Work

- We carry the vision; community sets the agenda
- National intermediary
- Thought leadership in philanthropy
- Integrated power-building model
- Field-shifting practice

A Final Word

Power-building only works because every department carries it. The conversations you have, the words you choose, and the way you represent the people we partner with are part of the cycle.

When community wisdom is resourced, advocated for, and connected at scale, decision-making power moves where it belongs. That is what we are building.

Thank you for the work.